bodies of the heroes towards the cremation side'. They had been hanged contrary to all expectation when they were meant eventually to have been released from death.

For Bhagat Singh, 'they were fearless patriots' and 'if they were misguided, if they were frenzied, let them be so' because 'whatever they did, they did it for this wretched country'. The Babbar Khalsa Akalis had taken violent action against government officials because they simply 'could not bear injustice' and 'they could not countenance the fallen nation'.[1] Since 'they could not tolerate the exploitation of the masses, they challenged and jumped into action'. The anguish in which Bhagat Singh found himself was plain as he exclaimed, 'Oh! The terrible toll of their dedicated deeds!',[2] while still acknowledging the atrocity for what it was with the words, 'even if' it was the case that they 'might have done something hateful, their courage and the dedication shown in surrendering their lives at the altar of the nation, is something to the opposite side . . .'.[3] In anger, he upbraided those who were too preoccupied with the festivities of Holi on this day, pointing out how 'we the cowards and human wretches lack the courage of even sighing and putting off our celebrations even for a moment. What a disheartening deed!'.[4] Rhetorically, he asked, 'Where is the end of sacrifice? Where is the limit to courage and fearlessness? Where does the extremity of idealism reside?'[5] All this Bhagat Singh was pondering over when he was barely twenty years of age.

The historian Moffat, who has conducted cutting-edge research into India's revolutionary tradition, states that what Bhagat Singh is doing here is engaging in 'appeals to the global landscape of rebellion'.[6] Whereas this is no doubt true, it is possible to also draw the inference that at age twenty what Bhagat Singh is doing is undergoing his own transformation into a revolutionary in the mould of those who went before him. He is learning. And he is learning how to die. In fact, he is on the path of emulating those whom he described as 'fearless patriots' and 'heroes'. Just as there was no respite or reprieve for them, he begins to learn that when it comes to it, there will be no respite or reprieve for him. All the characteristics of his own life, from the day of his own arrest on 8 April 1929 to the trial, in